



THE FUTURE OF COMMUNICATIONS & ITS ROLE IN GLOBALISATION

Leading through technology

"We are becoming lifestyle providers"

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I am happy to speak about technology trends and what they hold for globalisation because I have been personally working in this space for some years now. I can say with a great deal of certainty and authority that there has been nothing more profound as communications on the face of this earth. In particular, the last six or seven years have completely transformed the way the world works and I would like to share with you from an entrepreneurial point of view, how one is managing to stay ahead and in some cases in tune with the changes in technology that are taking place and changing the face of this earth and truly contributing towards globalisation.

What we see today is just the basic platform of what a very new world order is going to emerge in the coming 10 or 15 years. Whatever was the wow factor of today is fast and very fast turning into a given of tomorrow. In fact, I must share with you where the future generations are moving on to. I was in New York with my daughter, she met Arun Sarin and his daughter and they met the first time and they truly wanted to stay in touch and when they left, all they did was a handshake and when I asked my daughter, you haven't even exchanged email ID or a phone number, she said, "Dad, we don't need to, I will meet with her on the Facebook" and that is the new world order.

Boundaries are blurring now. Cable televisions are now providing telephony. Most of the cable network operators in the US are now providing high quality telephony including broad-band; but more importantly, the telecom companies are striking back as well. The standard old poor man's telephone, the switched copper pair, is now carrying IPTV. India will soon be waking up to IPTV in the coming weeks itself where we can actually do massive amounts of interactive TV viewing and then, of course, the DTH which is coming up in shape now, even in India, the satellite television. More importantly, what you are going to see now is machine-to-machine interface. Most of the mobile phones now carry a tiny little chip which is a GPS and talks to a satellite, doing a lot of functions—from fleet-management, remote reading of electricity meters to online transmission of languages. These devices are invisible and this is where the next wave will take place.

Today, technology allows you to go deeper and deeper into the country to those customers who we could have never

imagined would be on the telecom network ever in their life time. Today, people coming on the network are earning daily wages of Rs 60 to Rs 100 a day. Prices of storage, processing, devices are coming down. Camera prices are coming down from \$2,000 to Rs 25,000. Imagine, where this will lead us five years from now. And when it comes to that level, then obviously your mobile phone becomes your video camera, your camera and a full-scale computer. The world is now producing more transistors than grains of rice.

These are mind boggling shifts in technological trends. Speech recognition is becoming very very good. Today, the American troops in Iraq are constantly conversing with their local Iraqi counterparts. Online real time, he speaks in Iraqi, he speaks back in English, this is happening now. Give it two to three years, a Chinese will converse with anybody in India and he will blabber in Hindi, you will get a response from him back in Hindi although he will be speaking in Chinese. What will this do to the world? Will this not make the globe as one?

RAVI S. SAHNI

"IN THE NEAR FUTURE, MY PHONE WILL TELL ME ALL ABOUT MY FRIENDS IN A KILOMETRE RADIUS."

Sunil Bharti Mittal

